THE WAR OF CHIOGGIA

The conflict known as the War of Chioggia (1378–81) was the last fling in the long struggle between Venice and Genoa. In alliance with Hungary and Padua, the Genoese came close to inflicting a humiliating defeat on their Venetian enemies.

Venice's problems began in the spring of 1379. A fleet commanded by Vettor Pisani—nephew of the Niccolo Pisani defeated at Modon and one of Venice's most successful admirals—had wintered at Pola in the northern Adriatic. The galleys were still there on May 7, refitting and taking on supplies, when a Genoese squadron appeared at the harbor mouth. Pisani had only 16 galleys ready for action, but this seemed enough since the Genoese galleys in sight numbered 14. When the Venetians went out to give battle, however, 10 more enemy galleys appeared from behind a headland. After fierce fighting most of the Venetian galleys were captured along with their crews. Pisani survived but, on his return to Venice, was permanently banned from holding a command and, for a time, clapped in irons.

The destruction of its galleys at Pola put Venice at great risk. Its other major fleet, commanded by Carlo Zeno, was far away, commerce raiding in the eastern Mediterranean. Doge Andrea Contarini hastily improved the defenses of the city, but could do nothing to prevent a reinforced Genoese fleet of 47 galleys under Pietro Doria entering the Venetian lagoon in early August. With the aid of the land forces of Francesco da Carrara, lord of Padua, Doria seized the port of Chioggia at the southern end of the lagoon.

Pisani was immensely popular with his sailors—he was known as the "chief and father of all the seamen of Venice."



Venetian and Genoese gold coins
Both republics introduced gold coinage in the 13th century in imitation of the Byzantine Empire and the Arab world. The coins shown here are a Genoese grosso (below) and a Venetian ducat or sequin (above).



THIRD VENETIAN–GENOESE WAR

BOSPHORUS



Date February 13, 1352
Forces Venetians, Aragonese, Byzantines: 78 ships; Genoese: 64 ships
Losses Unknown

Location Near Constantinople

In its third war with Genoa, Venice was allied with Aragon, which included Catalonia, and the Byzantine Empire. In February 1352, Paganino Doria's Genoese fleet was wintering on the Bosphorus when a fleet of mostly Venetian and Catalan galleys under Niccolo Pisani appeared. The Genoese came out to give battle and a fierce action ensued, fought beyond nightfall in strong winds and rough seas. Next day Pisani judged his fleet no longer in fit shape to continue and withdrew.

THIRD VENETIAN–GENOESE WAR

ALGHERO



Date August 29, 1353
Forces Venetians and Aragonese: unknown; Genoese: unknown
Losses Venetians and Aragonese: unknown; Genoese: 33 galleys

Location Off Sardinia

After the battle of the Bosphorus the Byzantines made peace with Genoa, but the war continued. In summer 1353 the Aragonese were fighting for control of Sardinia, supported by a force of Venetian and Catalan galleys under Niccolo Pisani. The Genoese, without their inspired admiral Paganino Doria, were defeated in another fierce battle. Pisani took 4,500 prisoners, most of whom were executed. Genoa was then forced to accept rule by Milan as the price for financing a new fleet.

THIRD VENETIAN–GENOESE WAR

MODON



Date November 3, 1354
Forces Venetians: unknown; Genoese: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Gulf of Sapienza, Peloponnese

In 1354 Niccolo Pisani anchored his fleet for the winter at Porto Longo, near Modon. The Genoese had rebuilt their fleet with Milanese money after the defeat at Alghero, so Paganino Doria sailed to Porto Longo to challenge the Venetians to fight. Outnumbered, Pisani refused, so the Genoese penetrated the harbor and overwhelmed the Venetians, capturing Pisani and many others. Venice made peace shortly afterward.